

'Why?'

'Well—it sounds snobbish perhaps—but she's not a lady, not in any sense of the word.'

Poirot nodded thoughtfully. There was less rallery in his voice as he asked:

'You believe, then, in birth and breeding?'

'I may be old-fashioned, but I certainly don't believe in marrying out of one's class. It never answers.'

'I agree with you, *mon ami*. Ninety-nine times out of a hundred, it is as you say. But there is always the hundredth time! Still, that does not arise, as you do not propose to see the lady again.'

His last words were almost a question, and I was aware of the sharpness with which he darted a glance at me. And before my eyes, writ large in letters of fire, I saw the words 'Hôtel du Phare,' and I heard again her voice saying 'Come and look me up' and my own answering with *empressement*: 'I will.'

Well, what of it? I had meant to go at the time. But since then, I had had time to reflect. I did not like the girl. Thinking it over in cold blood, I came definitely to the conclusion that I disliked her intensely. I had got hauled over the coals for foolishly gratifying her morbid curiosity, and I had not the least wish to see her again.

I answered Poirot lightly enough.

'She asked me to look her up, but of course I shan't.'

'Why "of course"?'

'Well—I don't want to.'

'I see.' He studied me attentively for some minutes. 'Yes. I see very well. And you are wise. Stick to what you have said.'

'That seems to be your invariable advice,' I remarked, rather piqued.

'Ah, my friend, have faith in Papa Poirot. Some day, if you permit, I will arrange you a marriage of great suitability.'

'Thank you,' I said laughing, but the prospect leaves me cold.'

Poirot sighed and shook his head.

'*Les Anglais!*' he murmured. 'No method—absolutely none whatever. They leave all to chance!' He frowned, and altered the position of the salt cellar.

'Mademoiselle Cinderella is staying at the Hôtel d'Angleterre you told me, did you not?'

'No. Hôtel du Phare.'

'True, I forgot.'

A moment's misgiving shot across my mind. Surely I had never mentioned any hotel to Poirot. I looked across at him, and felt reassured. He was cutting his bread into neat little squares, completely absorbed in his task. He must have fancied I had told him where the girl was staying.

We had coffee outside facing the sea. Poirot smoked one of his tiny cigarettes, and then drew his watch from his pocket.

'The train to Paris leaves at 2:25,' he observed. 'I should be starting.'

'Paris?' I cried.

'That is what I said, *mon ami*.'

'You are going to Paris? But why?'

He replied very seriously.

'To look for the murderer of M. Renauld.'

'You think he is in Paris?'

'I am quite certain that he is not. Nevertheless, it is there that I must look for him. You do not understand, but I will explain it all to you in good time. Believe me, this journey to Paris is necessary. I shall not be away long. In all probability I shall return tomorrow. I do not propose that you should accompany me. Remain here and keep an eye on Giraud. Also cultivate the society of M. Renauld *filis*. And thirdly, if you wish, endeavour to cut him out with Mademoiselle Marthe. But I fear you will not have great success.'

I did not quite relish the last remark.

'That reminds me,' I said. 'I meant to ask you how you knew about those two?'

'*Mon ami*—I know human nature. Throw together a boy young Renauld and a beautiful girl like Mademoiselle Marthe, and the result is almost inevitable. Then, the quarrel! It was money or a woman and, remembering Léonie's description of the lad's anger, I decided on the latter. So I made my guess—and I was right.'

'And that was why you warned me against setting my heart on the lady? You already suspected that she loved young Renauld?'

Poirot smiled.

'At any rate—I saw that she had anxious eyes. That is how always think of Mademoiselle Daubreuil as the girl with the anxious eyes...'

His voice was so grave that it impressed me uncomfortably.

'What do you mean by that, Poirot?'

'I fancy, my friend, that we shall see before very long. But I must start.'

'You've oceans of time.'

'Perhaps—perhaps. But I like plenty of leisure at the station. I do not wish to rush, to hurry, to excite myself.'

'At all events,' I said, rising, 'I will come and see you off.'

'You will do nothing of the sort. I forbid it.'

He was so peremptory that I stared at him in surprise. He nodded emphatically.

'I mean it, *mon ami*. Au revoir! You permit that I embrace you? Ah, no, I forget that it is not the English custom. Une poignée de main, alors.'

I felt rather at a loose end after Poirot had left me. I strolled down the beach, and watched the bathers, without feeling energetic enough to join them. I rather fancied that Cinderella might be disporting herself amongst them in some wonderful costume, but I saw no signs of her. I strolled aimlessly along the sands towards the further end of the town. It occurred to me that, after all, it would only be decent feeling on my part to inquire after the girl. And it would save trouble in the end. The matter would then be finished with. There would be no need for me to trouble about her any further. But, if I did not go at all, she might quite possibly come and look me up at the Villa. And that would be annoying in every way. Decidedly it would be better to pay a short call, in the course of which I could make it quite clear that I could do nothing further for her in my capacity of showman.

Accordingly I left the beach, and walked inland. I soon found the Hôtel du Phare, a very unpretentious building. It was annoying in the extreme not to know the lady's name and, to save my dignity, I decided to stroll inside and look around. Probably I should find her in the lounge. Merlinville was a small place, you left your hotel to go to the beach, and you left the beach to return to the hotel. There were no other attractions. There was a Casino being built, but it was not yet completed.

I had walked the length of the beach without seeing her, therefore she must be in the hotel. I went in. Several people were sitting in the

Chapter 13

The Girl with the Anxious Eyes

ILunched with an excellent appetite. I understood well enough that Poirot did not wish to discuss the tragedy where we could so easily be overheard. But, as is usual when one topic fills the mind to the exclusion of everything else, no other subject of interest seemed to present itself. For a while we ate in silence, and then Poirot observed maliciously:

'*Eh bien !* And your indiscretions! You recount them not?'

I felt myself blushing.

'Oh, you mean this morning?' I endeavoured to adopt a tone of absolute nonchalance.

But I was no match for Poirot. In a very few minutes he had extracted the whole story from me, his eyes twinkling as he did so.

'*Tiens !* A story of the most romantic. What is her name, this charming young lady?'

I had to confess that I did not know.

'Still more romantic! The first *rencontre* in the train from Paris, the second here. Journeys end in lovers' meetings, is not that the saying?'

'Don't be an ass, Poirot.'

'Yesterday it was Mademoiselle Daubreuil, today it is Mademoiselle—Cinderella! Decidedly you have the heart of a Turk, Hastings! You should establish a harem!'

'It's all very well to rag me. Mademoiselle Daubreuil is a very beautiful girl, and I do admire her immensely—I don't mind admitting it. The other's nothing—don't suppose I shall ever see her again. She was quite amusing to talk to just for a railway journey, but she's not the kind of girl I should ever get keen on.'

tiny lounge, but my quarry was not amongst them. I looked into some other rooms, but there was no sign of her. I waited for some time, till my impatience got the better of me. I took the concierge aside, and slipped five francs into his hand.

‘I wish to see a lady who is staying here. A young English lady, small and dark. I am not sure of her name.’

The man shook his head, and seemed to be suppressing a grin.

‘There is no such lady as you describe staying here.’

‘She is American possibly,’ I suggested. These fellows are so stupid.

But the man continued to shake his head.

‘No, monsieur. There are only six or seven English and American ladies altogether, and they are all much older than the lady you are seeking. It is not here that you will find her, monsieur.’

He was so positive that I felt doubts.

‘But the lady told me she was staying here.’

‘Monsieur must have made a mistake—or it is more likely the lady did, since there has been another gentleman here inquiring for her.’

‘What is that you say?’ I cried, surprised.

‘But yes, monsieur. A gentleman who described her just as you have done.’

‘What was he like?’

‘He was a small gentleman, well dressed, very neat, very spotless, the moustache very stiff, the head of a peculiar shape, and the eyes green.’

Poirot! So that was why he refused to let me accompany him to the station. The impertinence of it! I would thank him not to meddle in my concerns. Did he fancy I needed a nurse to look after me? Thanking the man, I departed, somewhat at a loss, and still much incensed with my meddlesome friend. I regretted that he was, for the moment, out of reach. I should have enjoyed telling him what I thought of his unwarranted interference. Had I not distinctly told him that I had no intention of seeing the girl? Decidedly, one’s friends can be too zealous!

But where was the lady? I set aside my wrath, and tried to puzzle it out. Evidently, through inadvertence, she had named the wrong hotel. Then another thought struck me. Was it inadvertence? Or had she deliberately withheld her name and given me the wrong address? The more I thought about it, the more I felt convinced that this last surmise of mine was right.

For some reason or other she did not wish to let the acquaintance ripen into friendship. And though half an hour earlier this had been precisely my own view, I did not enjoy having the tables turned upon me. The whole affair was profoundly unsatisfactory, and I went up to the Villa Geneviève in a condition of distinct ill humour. I did not go to the house, but went up the path to the little bench by the shed, and sat there moodily enough.

I was distracted from my thoughts by the sound of voices close at hand. In a second or two I realized that they came, not from the garden I was in, but from the adjoining garden of the Villa Marguerite, and that they were approaching rapidly. A girl's voice was speaking, a voice that I recognized as that of the beautiful Marthe.

'*Chéri*,' she was saying, 'is it really true? Are all our troubles over?'

'You know it, Marthe,' Jack Renauld replied. 'Nothing can part us now, beloved. The last obstacle to our union is removed. Nothing can take you from me.'

'Nothing?' the girl murmured. 'Oh, Jack, Jack—I am afraid.'

I had moved to depart, realizing that I was quite unintentionally eaves-dropping. As I rose to my feet, I caught sight of them through a gap in the hedge. They stood together facing me, the man's arm round the girl, his eyes looking into hers. They were a splendid looking couple, the dark, well-knit boy, and the fair young goddess. They seemed made for each other as they stood there, happy in spite of the terrible tragedy that overshadowed their young lives.

But the girl's face was troubled, and Jack Renauld seemed to recognize it, as he held her closer to him and asked:

'But what are you afraid of, darling? What is there to fear—now?'

And then I saw the look in her eyes, the look Poirot had spoken of, as she murmured, so that I almost guessed at the words.

'I am afraid—for you...'

I did not hear young Renauld's answer, for my attention was distracted by an unusual appearance a little further down the hedge. There appeared to be a brown bush there, which seemed odd, to say the least of it, so early in the summer. I stepped along to investigate, but, at my advance, the brown bush withdrew itself precipitately, and faced me with a finger to its lips. It was Giraud.

consider it closely. Though its significance escapes you, be sure that it is significant.'

'In the meantime,' I said, considering, 'although we know a great deal more than we did, we are no nearer to solving the mystery of who killed Mr Renauld.'

'No,' said Poirot cheerfully. 'In fact we are a great deal further off.'

The fact seemed to afford him such peculiar satisfaction that I gazed at him in wonder. He met my eye and smiled.

'But yes, it is better so. Before, there was at all events a clear theory as to how and by whose hands he met his death. Now that is all gone. We are in darkness. A hundred conflicting points confuse and worry us. That is well. That is excellent. Out of confusion comes forth order. But if you find order to start with, if a crime seems simple and above-board, *eh bien, méfiez vous!* It is, how do you say it?—*cooked!* The great criminal is simple—but very few criminals *are* great. In trying to cover up their tracks, they invariably betray themselves. Ah, *mon ami*, I would that some day I could meet a really great criminal—one who commits his crime, and then—does nothing! Even I, Hercule Poirot, might fail to catch such a one.'

But I had not followed his words. A light had burst upon me.

'Poirot! Mrs Renauld! I see it now. She must be shielding somebody.'

From the quietness with which Poirot received my remark, I could see that the idea had already occurred to him.

'Yes,' he said thoughtfully. 'Shielding some one—or screening some one. One of the two.'

I saw very little difference between the two words, but I developed my theme with a good deal of earnestness. Poirot maintained a strictly non-committal attitude, repeating:

'It may be—yes, it may be. But as yet I do not know! There is something very deep underneath all this. You will see. Something very deep.'

Then, as we entered our hotel, he enjoined silence on me with a gesture.

dame Renauld? And why on earth should they return to the house to do so? In the second place, no man on earth would go out to keep an appointment wearing his underclothes and an overcoat. There are circumstances in which a man might wear pajamas and an overcoat—but the other, never!

'True,' I said, rather crest-fallen.

'No,' continued Poirot, 'we must look elsewhere for a solution of the open door mystery. One thing I am fairly sure of—they did not leave through the door. They left by the window.'

'What?'

'Precisely.'

'But there were no footmarks in the flower bed underneath.'

'No—and *there ought to have been*. Listen, Hastings. The gardener, Auguste, as you heard him say, planted both those beds the preceding afternoon. In the one there are plentiful impressions of his big hobnailed boots—in the other, *none*! You see? Some one had passed that way, some one who, to obliterate their footprints, smoothed over the surface of the bed with a rake.'

'Where did they get a rake?'

'Where they got the spade and the gardening gloves,' said Poirot impatiently. 'There is no difficulty about that.'

'What makes you think that they left that way, though? Surely it is more probable that they entered by the window, and left by the door.'

'That is possible of course. Yet I have a strong idea that they left by the window.'

'I think you are wrong.'

'Perhaps, *mon ami*.'

I mused, thinking over the new field of conjecture that Poirot's deductions had opened up to me. I recalled my wonder at his cryptic allusions to the flower bed and the wrist watch. His remarks had seemed so meaningless at the moment and now, for the first time, I realized how remarkably, from a few slight incidents, he had unravelled much of the mystery that surrounded the case. I paid a belated homage to my friend. As though he read my thoughts, he nodded sagely.

'Method, you comprehend! Method! Arrange your facts. Arrange your ideas. And if some little fact will not fit in—do not reject it but

Enjoining caution, he led the way round the shed until we were out of ear-shot.

'What were you doing there?' I asked.

'Exactly what you were doing—listening.'

'But I was not there on purpose!'

'Ah!' said Giraud. 'I was.'

As always, I admired the man whilst disliking him. He looked me up and down with a sort of contemptuous disfavour.

'You didn't help matters by butting in. I might have heard something useful in a minute. What have you done with your old fossil?'

'M. Poirot has gone to Paris,' I replied coldly.

'And I can tell you, M. Giraud, that he is anything but an old fossil. He has solved many cases that have completely baffled the English police.'

'Bah! The English police!' Giraud snapped his fingers disdainfully.

'They must be on a level with our examining magistrates. So he has gone to Paris, has he? Well, a good thing. The longer he stays there, the better. But what does he think he will find there?'

I thought I read in the question a tinge of uneasiness. I drew myself up.

'That I am not at liberty to say,' I said quietly.

Giraud subjected me to a piercing stare.

'He has probably enough sense not to tell *you*,' he remarked rudely.

'Good afternoon. I'm busy.'

And with that, he turned on his heel, and left me without ceremony. Matters seemed at a standstill at the Villa Geneviève. Giraud evidently did not desire my company and, from what I had seen, it seemed fairly certain that Jack Renauld did not either.

I went back to the town, had an enjoyable bath and returned to the hotel. I turned in early, wondering whether the following day would bring forth anything of interest.

I was wholly unprepared for what it did bring forth. I was eating my petit déjeuner in the dining-room, when the waiter, who had been talking to some one outside, came back in obvious excitement. He hesitated for a minute, fidgeting with his napkin, and then burst out.

'Monsieur will pardon me, but he is connected, is he not, with the affair at the Villa Geneviève?'

'Yes,' I said eagerly. 'Why?'

'Monsieur has not heard the news, though?'

'What news?'

'That there has been another murder there last night!'

'What?'

Leaving my breakfast, I caught up my hat and ran as fast as I could. Another murder—and Poirot away! What fatality. But who had been murdered?

I dashed in at the gate. A group of the servants was in the drive, talking and gesticulating. I caught hold of Françoise.

'What has happened?'

'Oh, monsieur! monsieur! Another death! It is terrible. There is a curse upon the house. But yes, I say it, a curse! They should send for M. le curé to bring some holy water. Never will I sleep another night under that roof. It might be my turn, who knows?' She crossed herself.

'Yes,' I cried, 'but who has been killed?'

'Do I know—me? A man—a stranger. They found him up there—in the shed—not a hundred yards from where they found poor Monsieur. And that is not all. He is stabbed—stabbed to the heart *with the same dagger!*'

of unusual character. At first, as I told you, I was inclined to suspect her of being concerned in the crime. Afterwards I altered my opinion.'

'What made you do that?'

'Her spontaneous and genuine grief at the sight of her husband's body. I could swear that the agony in that cry of hers was genuine.'

'Yes,' I said thoughtfully, 'one cannot mistake these things.'

'I beg your pardon, my friend—one can always be mistaken. Regard a great actress, does not her acting of grief carry you away and impress you with its reality? No, however strong my own impression and belief, I needed other evidence before I allowed myself to be satisfied. The great criminal can be a great actor. I base my certainty in this case, not upon my own impression, but upon the undeniable fact that Mrs Renauld actually fainted. I turned up her eyelids and felt her pulse. There was no deception—the swoon was genuine. Therefore I was satisfied that her anguish was real and not assumed. Besides, a small additional point not without interest, it was unnecessary for Mrs Renauld to exhibit unrestrained grief. She had had one paroxysm on learning of her husband's death, and there would be no need for her to simulate another such a violent one on beholding his body. No, Mrs Renauld was not her husband's murderess. But why has she lied? She lied about the wrist watch, she lied about the masked men—she lied about a third thing. Tell me, Hastings, what is your explanation of the open door?'

'Well,' I said, rather embarrassed, 'I suppose it was an oversight. They forgot to shut it.'

Poirot shook his head, and sighed.

'That is the explanation of Giraud. It does not satisfy me. There is a meaning behind that open door which for a moment I cannot fathom.'

'I have an idea,' I cried suddenly.

'*A la bonne heure!* Let us hear it.'

'Listen. We are agreed that Mrs Renauld's story is a fabrication. Is it not possible, then, that Mr Renauld left the house to keep an appointment—possibly with the murderer—leaving the front door open for his return. But he did not return, and the next morning he is found, stabbed in the back.'

'An admirable theory, Hastings, but for two facts which you have characteristically overlooked. In the first place, who gagged and bound Ma-

His words took me so much aback that I hardly knew how to respond.

He went on serenely:

'You heard me say to Giraud, did you not, that all the details of this crime were familiar to me? *Eh bien*, that presupposes one of two things, either the brain that planned the first crime also planned this one, or else an account read of a *cause célèbre* unconsciously remained in our assassin's memory and prompted the details. I shall be able to pronounce definitely on that after — ' he broke off.

I was revolving sundry matters in my mind.

'But Mr Renauld's letter? It distinctly mentions a secret and Santiago?'

'Undoubtedly there was a secret in M. Renauld's life—there can be no doubt of that. On the other hand, the word Santiago, to my mind, is a red herring, dragged continually across the track to put us off the scent. It is possible that it was used in the same way on M. Renauld, to keep him from directing his suspicions into a quarter nearer at hand. Oh, be assured, Hastings, the danger that threatened him was not in Santiago, it was near at hand, in France.'

He spoke so gravely, and with such assurance, that I could not fail to be convinced. But I essayed one final objection:

'And the match and cigarette end found near the body? What of them.'

A light of pure enjoyment lit up Poirot's face.

'Planted! Deliberately planted there for Giraud or one of his tribe to find! Ah, he is smart, Giraud, he can do his tricks! So can a good retriever dog. He comes in so pleased with himself. For hours he has crawled on his stomach. "See what I have found," he says. And then again to me: "What do you see here?" Me, I answer, with profound and deep truth, "Nothing." And Giraud, the great Giraud, he laughs, he thinks to himself, "Oh, that he is imbecile, this old one!" But *we shall see...*'

But my mind had reverted to the main facts.

'Then all this story of the masked men—?'

'Is false.'

'What really happened?'

Poirot shrugged his shoulders.

'One person could tell us—Madame Renauld. But she will not speak. Threats and entreaties would not move her. A remarkable woman that, Hastings. I recognized as soon as I saw her that I had to deal with a woman

Chapter 14

The Second Body

WAITING for no more, I turned and ran up the path to the shed. The two men on guard there stood aside to let me pass and, filled with excitement, I entered.

The light was dim, the place was a mere rough wooden erection to keep old pots and tools in. I had entered impetuously, but on the threshold I checked myself, fascinated by the spectacle before me.

Giraud was on his hands and knees, a pocket torch in his hand with which he was examining every inch of the ground. He looked up with a frown at my entrance, then his face relaxed a little in a sort of good-humoured contempt.

'Ah, *c'est l'Anglais!* Enter then. Let us see what you can make of this affair.'

Rather stung by his tone, I stooped my head, and passed in.

'There he is,' said Giraud, flashing his torch to the far corner.

I stepped across.

The dead man lay straight upon his back. He was of medium height, swarthy of complexion, and possibly about fifty years of age. He was neatly dressed in a dark blue suit, well cut and probably made by an expensive tailor, but not new. His face was terribly convulsed, and on his left side, just over the heart, the hilt of a dagger stood up, black and shining. I recognized it. It was the same dagger I had seen reposing in the glass jar the preceding morning!

'I'm expecting the doctor any minute,' explained Giraud. 'Although we hardly need him. There's no doubt what the man died of. He was stabbed to the heart, and death must have been pretty well instantaneous.' 'When was it done? Last night?'

Giraud shook his head.

'Hardly. I don't lay down the law on medical evidence, but the man's been dead well over twelve hours. When do you say you last saw that dagger?'

'About ten o'clock yesterday morning.'

'Then I should be inclined to fix the crime as being done not long after that.'

'But people were passing and repassing this shed continually.'

Giraud laughed disagreeably.

'You progress to a marvel! Who told you he was killed in this shed?'

'Well—' I felt flustered. 'I—I assumed it.'

'Oh, what a fine detective! Look at him, *mon petit*—does a man stabbed to the heart fall like that—nearly with his feet together, and his arms to his side? No. Again does a man lie down on his back and permit himself to be stabbed without raising a hand to defend himself? It is absurd, is it not? But see here—and here—' He flashed the torch along the ground. I saw curious irregular marks in the soft dirt. 'He was dragged here after he was dead. Half dragged, half carried by two people. Their tracks do not show on the hard ground outside, and here they have been careful to obliterate them—but one of the two was a woman, my young friend.'

'A woman?'

'Yes.'

'But if the tracks are obliterated, how do you know?'

'Because, blurred as they are, the prints of the woman's shoe are unmistakable. Also, by *this*—' And, leaning forward, he drew something from the handle of the dagger and held it up for me to see. It was a woman's long black hair—similar to the one Poirot had taken from the arm-chair in the library.

With a slightly ironic smile he wound it round the dagger again.

'We will leave things as they are as much as possible,' he explained. 'It pleases the examining magistrate. *Et bien*, do you notice anything else?' I was forced to shake my head.

'Look at his hands.'

I did. The nails were broken and discoloured, and the skin was hard. It hardly enlightened me as much as I should have liked it to have done. I looked up at Giraud.

Hercule Poirot, say that Madame Renaud lied. *The crime took place at least two hours earlier.*

'But the doctors—'

'They declared, after examination of the body, that death had taken place between ten and seven hours previously. *Mon ami*, for some reason, it was imperative that the crime should seem to have taken place later than it actually did. You have read of a smashed watch or clock recording the exact hour of a crime? So that the time should not rest on Mrs Renaud's testimony alone, some one moved on the hands of that wrist watch to two o'clock, and then dashed it violently to the ground. But, as is often the case, they defeated their own object. The glass was smashed, but the mechanism of the watch was uninjured. It was a most disastrous manoeuvre on their part, for it at once drew my attention to two points—first, that Madame Renaud was lying; secondly, that there must be some vital reason for the postponement of the time.'

'But what reason could there be?'

'Ah, that is the question! There we have the whole mystery. As yet, I cannot explain it. There is only one idea that presents itself to me as having a possible connection.'

'And that is?'

'The last train left Merlinville at seventeen minutes past twelve.'

I followed it out slowly.

'So that, the crime apparently taking place some two hours later, any one leaving by that train would have an unimpeachable alibi!'

'Perfect, Hastings! You have it!'

I sprang up.

'But we must inquire at the station. Surely they cannot have failed to notice two foreigners who left by that train! We must go there at once!'

'You think so, Hastings?'

'Of course. Let us go there now.'

Poirot restrained my ardour with a light touch upon the arm.

'Go by all means if you wish, *mon ami*—but if you go, I should not ask for particulars of two foreigners.'

I stared, and he said rather impatiently:

'Là, là, you do not believe all that rigmarole, do you? The masked men and all the rest of *cette histoire-là*!'